for ‘European ticket collectors…(to) beat or rather kick’ the passengers, and those who went to the station to see friends were ‘very harshly treated by the police, turned out of the station, beaten and kept in restraint’ so that it was very humiliating for ‘any respectable Hindustanee to travel by railway’. [71]

THE IRON WEB SPREADS

The Mutiny led the railway planners to lay lines faster and more strategically. The next two decades saw more companies and more lines across the subcontinent. The Sind and Punjab Railway Company expanded northward from Karachi and formed two new lines, the Lahore-Multan line and the Lahore-Delhi line. The Scinde Railway opened its Karachi-Kotri section to the public in 1861, the first in the region that would later become Pakistan. Down south, the Madras Railway was extended to Beypur/Kadalundi (near Calicut) and work began on a north-western branch out of Arakkonam. Further down, the first line projected by the Great Southern of India Railway Company (as the South Indian Railway Company was formerly called) was from Negapatam to Erode through Trichinopoly. The section of this which runs from Negapatam to Trichinopoly fort was constructed in the standard gauge and completed for traffic in 1862, and the line was opened as far as Karur in 1866, and as far as Erode two years later. [72] As lines, locomotives and wagons multiplied, bigger workshops were set up. The legendary Jamalpur Loco Workshop was set up the same year.

The East Indian Railway Company’s Delhi-Calcutta route progressed as far as the west bank of the Yamuna, via Mughalsarai and the Sahibganj loop. By 1 August 1864, the first train from Calcutta had reached Delhi. There were through trains running between Delhi and Calcutta. Rail coaches were ferried on boats across the river at Allahabad. Delhi and Calcutta were linked directly by 1866, as the completion of the Yamuna bridge (road and rail) in Delhi allowed trains to reach what later became Delhi Junction.

By 1867, the East Indian Railway extended from Allahabad to Jubbulpore (Jabalpur), and the GIPR’s north-east line reached Jubbulpore from Itarsi, linking up with the East Indian Railway track there at Allahabad, and establishing connectivity between Bombay and Calcutta.

Pushed initially by trade and import necessity and later by strategic need, the grip of the iron network over the subcontinent was stronger than